

FRED TALKS

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The Self-Help Trap: What 20+ Years of “Optimizing” Has Taught Me

TIM FERRISS · 08 MAR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

One danger of modern self-help.

“We cannot reason ourselves out of our basic irrationality. All we can do is to learn the art of being irrational in a reasonable way.”
— Aldous Huxley, *Island*

It was cold out, but none of us were cold.

I sat with five men in the mountains of Montana. As the sun set, the fire in the center cast dancing light on our faces. Reclined against fallen trees in a tight circle, we ate mushrooms and fish we’d found under trees and along streams. The whole crew burst into laughter yet again, and one of the guides passed around a fresh batch of pine needle tea.

Bathed in warmth, I took off a layer and glanced skyward through an opening in the trees. The stars shone like crystals on black velvet, and the show—the biggest meteor shower of the year—was starting.

In that moment, there was nothing to do. Nothing to improve. Nothing to fix.

It was perfect.

The older I get, the more I think that self-help can be a trap. Sometimes the cure is worse than the disease. I say this after ~20 years of writing self-help and a lifetime of consuming it.

Spend enough time in the world of “improvement,” and you’ll notice something strange: The people most obsessed with self-help are often the least helped by it. Behind the smiles and motivational quotes, behind closed doors and after a drink or two, the truth is that they’re not able to outsmart their worries.

On one hand, perhaps this unhappiness is precisely what lands one in self-development in the first place, right? I long assumed this about myself, and it’s partially true.

On the other hand, what if self-help *itself* is actually creating or amplifying unhappiness?

Auto-calculated kinda related posts:

If you enjoyed this post, please consider sharing it by email or on social media. [Here’s the link.](#)
Thanks, —Matt.

Results Age

XKCD.COM · 13 MAY 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

IMPLICATIONS OF THE AGE OF THE POSTS YOU SEE WHEN YOU GOOGLE AN ERROR MESSAGE		
ERROR CODE: E-303 (3 YEARS AGO)		
AGE OF POST	WHAT IT MEANS	PROBABILITY OF A FIX
2 HOURS AGO	THINGS ARE WORKING SOME DUNGE.	VERY HIGH—JUST WAIT
5 DAYS AGO	A RECENT UPDATE BROKE SOMETHING SO	HEA, BUT YOU MIGHT HAVE TO WAIT FOR A REE
3 MONTHS AGO	A NEW PRODUCT OF A SOLUTION OF SOME USERS	DECENT CHANCE OF A SOLUTION IN THE REPLES
2 YEARS AGO	YOUVE RUN INTO AN URGIC CASE	LOU, BUT PRAISE THE REEDED CAN HELP WITH TROUBLESHOOTING
15 YEARS AGO	YOUVE RE ONLY TONKAL WITH THE PROBLEM	VERY LOW—POST IS LIKELY NOT RELEVANT
24 YEARS AGO	OH GOD YOU IS THE INTERNET THIS OLD	POSSIBLE UNUSUAL POSTED THIS MESSAGE AND KEE WHO CAN HELP YOU

Please, we need your help. Our research suggests you're the last living descendant of the person who knew how to format this config file.

So from a usability perspective I see front-end as somewhat sacrificial. AI agents will drive straight through it; users will encounter it only once or twice; it will be customised or personalised; all that work on optimising user journeys doesn't matter any more.

But from a vibe perspective, services are not fungible. e.g. if you're finding a restaurant then Yelp, Google Maps, Resy, and The Infatuation are all more-or-less equivalent for answering that question but clearly they are completely different and you'll use different services at different times.

Understanding that a service is *for you* is 50% an unconscious process - we call it brand - and I look forward to front-end design for apps and services optimising for brand rather than ease of use.

If I were a bank, I would be releasing a hardened CLI tool like *yesterday*.

There is so much to figure out:

- How do permissions work? Should the user get a notification from their phone app when the agent strays outside normal behaviour? How do I give it credentials to act on my behalf, and how long do they last?
- How does adjacency work? My bank gives me a current account in exchange for putting a "hey, get a loan!" button on the app home screen. How do you make offers to an agent?

Headless banks.

Headless government?

I'd love to show you a worked example here. I vibed up a suite of four CLI tools that wrap four different services from UK government departments.

If I were renting a house, I would set my agent to learning about the neighbourhoods using one of these tools. Another tool will be helpful next time I'm buying a used car. (There's a Companies House command-line tool too.)

But I won't show you the tools because I don't want to be responsible for maintaining and supporting them.

I wish Monzo came with an official CLI. I wish Booking.com came with a CLI. I reckon, give it a year, they will.

Modern self-help contains an in-built flaw:

To continually improve yourself, you must continually locate the ways you are broken.

Fortunately, there are a few perspective shifts that make all the difference. It took me embarrassingly long to figure them out.

To get started, let's take a fresh look at an old concept.

MASLOW'S HIERARCHY OF NEEDS?

"I suppose it is tempting, if the only tool you have is a hammer, to treat everything as if it were a nail."

— Abraham Maslow

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs has captured the minds of hundreds of millions. It offers simplicity in a terrifyingly complex world.

Abraham Maslow's "[A Theory of Human Motivation](#)" (1943) contains five levels, which are typically presented like the below pyramid. This one is pulled from [the Wikipedia entry](#) on the subject:

We've all seen it. Clear as day, you can see the goal post at the top: self-actualization.

LFG! It's time to journal and 80/20 myself! Pass me a shaman and some modafinil.

That's the mission. That's the point.

Right?

But hold on. A critical footnote got lost in the shuffle. In his later writings, especially notes compiled in *[The Farther Reaches of Human Nature](#)* (1971), Maslow added a *sixth* level above self-actualization:

Self-transcendence.

That update never quite made it out of the crib. The consultants are to blame, but that comes later.

Self-transcendence means going beyond the self — seeking connection with something greater, such as service to others, nature, art, or the divine. Why is it important? Well, for one thing, as [Tony Robbins](#) put it at an event long ago: “‘I, I, I, me, me, me’ gets to be a really fucking boring song.”

But it’s not just a boring song; it’s dangerous to your health.

DON’T BE A SOMO

“**The man who renounces himself, comes to himself.**”

— Ralph Waldo Emerson

Self-help is dangerous precisely because it easily becomes self-fixation.

A focus on improving the self usually first requires finding problems with the self. This is quite the pickle. In a society that rewards problem-solving, you can end up hallucinating or exaggerating unease in order to fix it. This leaves you always in the red, always one step behind. Imagine a dog chasing its tail that has committed to being unhappy until it catches the tail... but it’s always just a few inches short. Still, it whirls around and around, “doing the work.” Perfection always recedes by one more book, one more seminar, one more habit tracker.

Put in more colorful terms, misdirected self-help turns you into a self-obsessed masturbatory [ouroboros](#) (SOMO).

To remind me of the SOMO risk, I have this sticker on my laptop:

A picture is worth a thousand social media posts about yourself. Sticker from [Porous Walker](#).

Now, to be clear, I still love self-help. Ain’t no way Timmy can give up the sauce. There’s a place for it.

From The Bible to Seneca, and from Ben Franklin to Stephen Covey and far beyond, there’s a lot of valuable advice worth taking. I used to mainline it all – no time to waste! – and jump straight into action. This did some good, but there was a lot of collateral damage.

Why?

Because there are at least three “tectonic plates of self-help” that I couldn’t see for decades, and they dictate how much net-positive or net-negative comes from all the striving. Before you sprint, you want to calibrate your direction.

For one, AIs are really good at finding security holes. The new Mythos model from Anthropic is so good at discovering security flaws that it has been held back from the public and [governments are convening emergency meetings of the biggest banks](#).

And including a UI increasing complexity and makes security holes more likely.

Here’s a recent shocking example. Companies House is the national register of all companies, directors, and accounts for England and Wales. Users could view *and edit* any other user’s account:

a logged-in company director could exploit the flaw by starting from their own dashboard and then trying to log into another company’s account.

Once they reach the 2FA block, which they would not be able to pass, [all that was required was to click the browser’s back button a few times](#). Typically, the user would be taken back to their own dashboard, but the bug instead returned them to the company they had tried to log into but couldn’t.

This bug had been present since October 2025.

Imagine a future where personal AIs are filing company records, and one of them notices this security hole overnight and posts about it on [moltbook](#) or whatever agent-only social network is most popular. The other agents would exploit the system up, down and sideways before the engineering team woke up.

The only viable solution is that services need to security hardened, and to do that they need to be simplifying and minimised. Again, CLI tools are a great fit.

What does this mean for front-end design?

Design won’t go anywhere.

Sure, the front-end should be driving the same CLI tools that agents use.

Arguably it’s more important than ever: human users will encounter services, figure out what they can do, and pick up their vibe from using the app, just as now.

Then they’ll tell their personal AI about the service and never see the front-end again, or re-mix it into bespoke personal software.

- [Obsidian CLI](#) to do anything you can do with the (very popular) note-taking app - like keep daily notes, track and cross off tasks, search - from the CLI
- [Salesforce CLI](#) and, look, I don't really understand what the Salesforce business operating system does, but the fact it has a CLI too is significant.

And here is [CLI-Anything](#) (31k stars on GitHub) which auto-generates CLIs for ANY codebase.

Why CLIs?

It turns out that the best place for personal AIs to run is on a computer. Maybe a virtual computer in the cloud, but ideally your computer. That way they can see the docs that you can see, and use the tools that you can use, and so what they want is not APIs (which connect webservers) but little apps they can use directly. CLI tools are the perfect little apps.

CLIs are composable so they are a better fit for what users actually do.

By composable I mean you can: query your notes then jump to a spreadsheet then research the web then jump back to the spreadsheet then text the user a clarifying question then double-check your notes, all by bouncing between CLIs in the same session.

A while back app design got obsessed with “user journeys.” Like the journey of a user finding a hotel then booking a hotel then staying in it and leaving a review.

But users don't live in “journeys.” They multitask; they talk to people and come back to things; they're idiosyncratic Try grabbing the search results from the Airbnb app and popping them in a message to chat on the family WhatsApp, then coming back to it two days later. It's a pain and you have to use screenshots because apps and their user journeys are not composable.

CLIs are composable because they came originally from Unix and that is the [Unix tools philosophy](#): tools were designed so that they could operate together.

Personal AIs like Openclaw or [Poke](<https://poke.com>) do what users want and don't follow “designed” user journeys, and as a result the composed experience is more personal and way better. CLIs are a great underlying technology for that.

CLIs are smaller than regular apps and so they are easier to secure.

The alternative to providing special tools for AIs is that the AIs use the same browser-based apps that we do, and that's a terrifying prospect.

THE THREE TECTONIC PLATES OF SELF-HELP

“As to methods there may be a million and then some, but principles are few. The man who grasps principles can successfully select his own methods. The man who tries methods, ignoring principles, is sure to have trouble.”

— Harrington Emerson

In the last few years, my life has become much more of a joy than a grind, and that's because I've focused on three tectonic plates.

Let's take a close look at each.

1. Intention

Individual or Social?

Americans, in particular, worship at the altar of the rugged individualist. There are clear upsides to this. But steeped in a culture – offline and especially online – that puts the self on a pedestal, we can take self-improvement to be an end unto itself: a better self.

But is it an end unto itself? Does it automatically produce good things? I now have my doubts.

Here's one analogy I've drawn for myself.

Let's pretend that life is the game of soccer. You can work on the mechanics of soccer by yourself. You can always get better at dribbling, shooting, and running drills as a solo practitioner. You can read dozens of books, study tape, and earn a PhD in the physics of ball flight. You can post videos of stunning shots on YouTube and get showered by emojis.

But none of this is actually playing the game of soccer.

You can spend your whole life preparing for, instead of playing, the game of life.

But why would anyone, including yours truly, succumb to this?

Subconsciously, it spares you from the messiest but most rewarding game of all: human interaction. Perhaps people hurt or traumatized you long ago. You might also justify the endless polishing, as I did, with some version of “Once I've perfected myself, then I'll be ready for relationships.” But here's the rub: that practice is exactly endless. You can always get better at dribbling and penalty kicks.

Digging further, focusing on improving the self is often in service of trying to control the world, especially if things were unpredictable or unstable when growing up. Banish emotion, live by spreadsheets, and all can be well. All can be *controlled*, or so the illusion goes. But as soon as you're interacting with – let alone depending on – other people, control as a construct goes out the window. And so we consciously or subconsciously avoid the messiness. This is also one of the reasons why a lot of optimizing achiever folks have a hard time in intimate relationships.

So how do I think about “self-help” now, having realized all of the above?

It is refreshingly simple: the goal is to build and improve my relationships. The sooner you get on the real field with real players, the sooner you can get to playing soccer and engaging with life. No more auto-fellating, even with the best of intentions. We've evolved over millions of years to be deeply social creatures, and the more you dodge that IN REAL PHYSICAL LIFE, the more you will suffer. This is why solitary confinement in prisons is often considered cruel and unusual punishment... and yet we do it to ourselves all the time.

There are a few questions that help corral this tectonic plate of *intention*:

- How does any given “self-help” help me in my relationships, and how can I apply it with other people *today* or *this week*?
- How can I take the ship out of the harbor and test it where it counts?

2. Audience

Do you have an audience for your self-development? If so, be careful.

Nary a minute can be spent on social media without bumping into a CAPS-rich “HOW X CHANGED MY LIFE” or a photo carousel of an ayahuasca retreat. If only Costa Rica got a dime for every bikini-clad healer under a waterfall!

Welcome to the theater of performative self-help. I won't belabor this, as we've all seen it, but I suggest reading about the [insidious creep of audience capture here](#), and don't forge ahead in the fame game before reading [11 reasons not to become famous](#). It's hard to put the genie back in the bottle, so you should know what that genie will do to your life.

But the truth is that most of us aren't extreme examples of this. But even minor tendencies in this direction can do extreme damage over time.

⇐

Headless everything for personal AI

INTERCONNECTED · 18 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

It's pretty clear that apps and services are all going to have to go *headless*: that is, they will have to provide access and tools for personal AI agents without any of the visual UI that us humans use today.

By services I mean things like: getting a new passport; finding and booking a hotel or a flight; managing your bank account; shopping for t-shirts with a minimum cotton weight from brands similar to ones that you've bought from before.

Why? Because using personal AIs is a better experience for users than using services directly (honestly); and headless services are quicker and more dependable for the personal AIs than having them click round a GUI with a bot-controlled mouse.

Where this leaves design for the services... well, I have some thoughts on that.

Headless services? They're happening already.

Already there is [MCP, as previously discussed](#) (2025), a kind of web API specifically for AI. For instance, best-in-class call transcriber app Granola [recently released their MCP](#) and now you can ask your Claude to pull out the meeting actions and go trawling in your personal docs to find answers to all the question. A good integration.

But command-line tools are growing in popularity, although they used to be just for developers. So you can now create a spreadsheet by typing in your terminal:

```
gws sheets spreadsheets create --json '{"properties": {"title": "Q1 Budget"}}'
```

Here are some recently launched CLI tools:

- [gws](#): Google Workspace CLI, Drive, Gmail, Calendar, and every Workspace API. Zero boilerplate. Structured JSON output. 40+ agent skills included.

Final thoughts

In his original staff engineer post, Larson is pretty clear that these archetypes are more of an anthropological description of some of the varied niches staff engineers fill, not a how-to guide for succeeding in the role⁵. At the time, the “staff engineer” role was fairly new and people were still trying to figure out what it even meant. Pointing out that there were a few very different ways to succeed in the role was a genuinely novel observation.

The staff engineer archetypes are a good list of ways an engineer can be very useful to their organization - but only once they’ve built a deep relationship of trust with their organization’s leadership. Advice on how to succeed as a staff engineer should be about **how to build that trust**, not about what to do once you have it.

1. One caveat that is too pedantic for the body of the post: each tech company has a different structure of roles. Some don’t have the formal “staff” title at all, while others have “staff” as a fairly early rung on the ladder and a panoply of “senior staff”, “senior principal staff”, and so on roles above it. Like all “staff engineer” discourse, this post is not about the word itself but about the point in the engineering job ladder where progression becomes significantly more difficult.

↩

2. Impressing your VP’s trusted lieutenants can actually be a good way to build trust in the medium-term, but you’d better hope you’ve built enough understanding of the system to do it right. If this process goes badly, your reputation in the org might be torched for years.

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3. In theory, at least. In practice it’s always better to be useful (again, in the sense of “delivering shareholder value”).

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4. This is why very senior leadership sometimes seem so unempathetic towards engineering complaints: their work environment operates by very different rules and norms to that of most engineers. I keep meaning to try and write about this and never succeeding. This [draft](#) is the closest thing I have to a deeper exploration of the point.

↩

5. For the record, my how-to guides are [here](#) and [here](#).

Below are a few questions that I’ve found helpful for nudging this particular tectonic plate in the right direction:

- If you couldn’t tell a soul about “the work” you’re doing, would you still do it? If not, you’re not developing yourself; you’re curating yourself.
- How has sharing your personal development created tradeoffs?
- If you *had to* take down 20% of your most popular posts, which would you take down and why?
- Are you describing strong catalysts (psychedelics, The Hoffman Process, you name it) instead of doing the post-session integration that makes them truly valuable?
- Have you become more robust or more fragile by offering your inner workings up to public vote?
- Has your social presence made you more or less of the person you want to be? How would the you of three or five years ago feel about your last year of posts? What about the you of 10 years from now?

3. Assumption

What are the fundamental assumptions behind your doing “the work”?

Let’s begin with a [Buddhist parable](#) that I first heard from the incredible [Jack Kornfield](#).

The old Master points to a big boulder and asks a disciple, “See that large rock over there?”

“Yes”, says the disciple.

“Do you think it’s heavy?” continues the Master.

“Yes, it’s very heavy!” replies the student.

“Only if you pick it up,” smiles the Master.

Once again, the fundamental assumption behind self-help is often this: Something is not OK. Something is wrong. Something is not enough. Something needs fixing. If I can’t find it, I’ll create it.

We’ve established this. But there is a follow-on assumption that matters a lot.

If I fix the things that aren’t OK, all will be well. If I improve myself enough, if I only work hard enough, I can finally eliminate my suffering.

I hate to inform you, but this doesn’t work. I’m also thrilled to inform you that this doesn’t work. You can stop picking up a lot of boulders.

There is one book that most opened my eyes to this reframe – *Already Free: Buddhism Meets Psychotherapy on the Path of Liberation* by Bruce Tift. It offers a terrifying but ultimately liberating realization: there is no perfect escape from suffering. It doesn’t exist. But there is a way to find your long-sought unclenching, and it lies in cultivating your skill of acceptance as much as that of improvement.

Now, I can hear the chorus: *Has Tim gone soft? Given up the good fight? Is he telling everyone to chill after he himself red-lined and got the spoils? How convenient! And...*

Hold on a second. I’m telling you – intelligent acceptance is high-leverage. It’s probably one of the highest forms of leverage. This is an approach that helps preserve your energy for where it really matters. My early forays into Stoicism and Seneca The Younger helped set the conditions for my biggest wins from 2004-2010. Still, I only learned a small fraction of what I needed.

So how do you cultivate your skill of acceptance without becoming complacent?

This is a big question and what I love about Bruce’s book. Compared to a strictly Western or purely Eastern book, he blends them and offers a surgical guide to using *both* action and acceptance. You don’t have to be a bull in a china shop or a cow in the rain; there is a middle path. That middle path is where all the gold is buried.

If the only tool you have is “self-improvement,” you’ll become a hammer looking for nails in a world that is 50% screws. I tried it. It can create the veneer of success, but it will leave your inner world in turmoil.

Suffice to say, the dual dance is the most joyful. Upgrade your toolkit with that in mind. Read Bruce’s book. If it doesn’t click, try *Radical Acceptance: Embracing Your Life with the Heart of a Buddha* by Tara Brach, which had a large impact on my life a decade before I found Bruce’s book. In a sense, the writing of Seneca prepared me for Tara, which then prepared me for Bruce. So grab them all and thank me later.

If you want serenity, you need to be able to put the Serenity Prayer into practice. Seriously, I read it all the time.

What is a staff engineer?

A staff engineer has to be useful to the company. Of course, a senior or mid-level software engineer ought to be useful too, but all they *have* to do is execute on the job in front of them. If they end up not providing value (maybe their project turns out to be unimportant, or they don’t get the support needed to succeed) that’s their manager’s problem, not theirs³. In contrast, staff engineers are expected to deliver value regardless: to make the project work, or to find something else useful to do if the project truly can’t be salvaged.

This is an unfair expectation. Often projects really do fail through no fault of your own, and sometimes it just isn’t possible to conjure useful work from thin air. That’s actually by design: **the staff engineer role is supposed to be unfair**. Something many engineers don’t realize is that all senior management and executive leadership roles are unfair too, in the same way. That’s just part of the deal: executives are given power and great compensation, and in return they get thrown off the boat in bad weather⁴. “Staff engineer” is the first engineering role where you are held largely responsible for outcomes you don’t control.

Developing a “staff engineer mindset” thus has very little to do with the archetypes. Instead, you should:

1. Develop the habit of constantly asking yourself “is this useful to the company” (and answering correctly).
2. Lose the habit of worrying about if you’re being treated “fairly”. Instead, try to think about your role in terms of incentives and consequences.

At the beginning, you won’t look much like any of the staff engineer archetypes. You will look like being a level-headed engineer who can be trusted to move projects forward with a minimum of fuss, and who can be re-tasked to different work without complaining. You’ll also look like someone who’s paying a lot of attention to what their manager’s actual priorities are, and who is thinking hard about how to fulfil those priorities (instead of their own goals).

If you do this for long enough, you’ll eventually find yourself in one of the staff engineer archetypes. However, it probably won’t be the one you’re “aiming for”. The whole point of being a staff engineer is that you’re willing to fill whatever archetype the company needs at the time.

These archetypes definitely exist¹. However, I think it's bad practical advice to tell engineers to try and target them.

Archetypes do not make good goals

To see why, let's take the "team lead" archetype. Larson describes this as an informal technical leadership role: not necessarily an explicit authority figure, but someone who's good at scoping work, planning projects, and maintaining the kind of relationships (e.g. with other teams) needed to successfully ship. If you want to fill this role, shouldn't you start trying to do these things? No! You don't become a technical leader by trying really hard to be a technical leader, much like you don't become a writer by trying really hard "to be a writer". You become a technical leader by *doing good technical work* until your skills and relationships emerge organically.

I wrote about this process in *Ratchet effects determine engineer reputation at large companies*. To get good at shipping large complex projects, you must start by shipping tiny pieces of work, until you're familiar enough with the system and you've built enough trust to take on slightly larger pieces. At each stage, if you do good work - "good work" here means "deliver shareholder value" - you will very naturally be given opportunities to work on more complex and important things. If you try to jump ahead, you're going to run into all kinds of problems:

- Important projects are usually assigned top-down, not bottom-up, so you'll either be trying to muscle out the planned engineering lead for a project or to pitch your own (complex, important) engineering task to senior management. Either way, good luck with that!
- You likely won't have a good enough relationship with senior management to know what their real priorities are.
- If you're not yet trusted to execute, you may get assigned "minders" (often current staff engineers) who will ghost-lead the project through you².
- You'll likely make poor technical decisions.

The other archetypes are like this as well. If you want to become a successful architect, you do not get there by studying software architecture in the abstract, because you can't design software you don't work on. The "solver" and "right hand" archetypes both rely on having an enormous amount of trust and influence. You can't aim for those archetypes directly, because trust and influence accumulate over time. In fact, the idea of "aiming for" a particular staff engineer archetype reflects a misunderstanding of what the staff engineer role is. What is the defining attribute of the staff engineering role, then?

MASLOW'S HAMBURGER OF NEEDS?

"The more one forgets himself—by giving himself to a cause to serve or another person to love—the more human he is and the more he actualizes himself. What is called 'self-actualization' is not an attainable aim at all, for the simple reason that the more one would strive for it, the more he would miss it. In other words, self-actualization is possible only as a side-effect of self-transcendence."

— Viktor E. Frankl

How can we easily keep ourselves on the right track?

As I remind myself these days: **It's the relationships, stupid.**

For a nice simple visual, let's revise Maslow's pyramid with all of this in mind. This is easy, as Maslow never drew his model as a rigid pyramid!

He described "classes" of needs that were unfixed, overlapping, and that could reverse in order. And believe it or not, self-actualization was only ever for the "self-actualizing minority." In the 1960s, his work was co-opted by consultants and corporate trainers who needed a progression to sell. True story.

Given all this, and after decades of trial and error, here's where I've landed:

Maslow's Hamburger of Needs.

Ahhh... what? Not to worry. It's the same good ol' Maslow ingredients, but I think of it as a hamburger:

For our purposes, the meat, the whole point of the hamburger, is that middle layer: relationships. That is the center of life. The heartbeat.

As luck would have it, when you improve the heartbeat, it also feeds everything else.

You'll notice that the meat contains Abe's most-important addendum—the sixth level of self-transcendence. Focusing on things bigger than yourself is a critical piece of the ultimate puzzle. Faith, nature, family, meditation, causes that outlive you, etc. – take your pick. But be careful. If you do it to inflate the ego or impress others, it's self-obsession again, not self-transcendence. If you need credit, it doesn't count.

Of course, it should go without saying but the top and bottom layers matter a lot. A hamburger is a giant mess without the bun. Friends will get sick of you crashing on their couch and eating their food.

But the bread and dressing layers exist to serve the middle. That’s the payload. Everything is in service of the payload. And the payload circulates benefits back to the edges, and then the cycle repeats. Even if you think this is oversimplified claptrap, temporarily assuming it’s true will help you.

What if nearly everything you focused on — calendar, habits, goals — aimed to improve your relational life somehow? What if you took this as a challenge for even a week? Your lens on the world changes dramatically.

You say yes differently.

You say no more clearly.

Your to-do list for life slowly transforms.

What if all that you focused on, all that you do, had to improve that middle layer in some fashion?

It’s a damn hard question if you’ve been on the *self*-help train for a while. I get it.

So let’s try something easier: **What if it only changed how you approach your to-do list? Try hamburger-first each day for 1-2 weeks and tell me what happens. Add and do the things that improve your relational life FIRST. Nothing on the list? Create something. It could be as simple as cooking dinner for your spouse, complimenting at least three people a day for a week, or introducing yourself to the barista you see every morning. Getting started is how you get grooving.**

ARE YOU DOING SELF-HELP, OR IS SELF-HELP DOING YOU?

For friendship makes prosperity more shining and lessens adversity by dividing and sharing it.

— Marcus Tullius Cicero

In his *Moral Letters to Lucilius*, Seneca the Younger famously wrote that “These individuals [who put money at the center of life] have riches just as we say that we ‘have a fever,’ when really the fever has us.”

What if self-help is similar?

Obsessing over the self never provides peace. It cannot make you whole, as you aren’t the whole. Becoming whole starts by putting down the rock you didn’t even know you were carrying.

Because at the end of the day—and at the end of a Montana night—the point was never yourself.

It was never the pyramid.

It was never the optimization.

It was the people around the fire.

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Why I don't like the "staff engineer archetypes"

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The most influential piece of writing about staff engineers in the last decade has to be Will Larson’s *Staff engineer archetypes*. He argues that the “staff engineer” title covers at least four very different roles: the team lead, the architect, the solver, and the right hand. This taxonomy gets cited a lot as advice for people who are trying to become effective staff engineers. For [both](#) of my promotions to staff engineer, my manager at the time linked me to the “staff engineer archetypes” and asked me to consider which of these archetypes I was aiming towards.